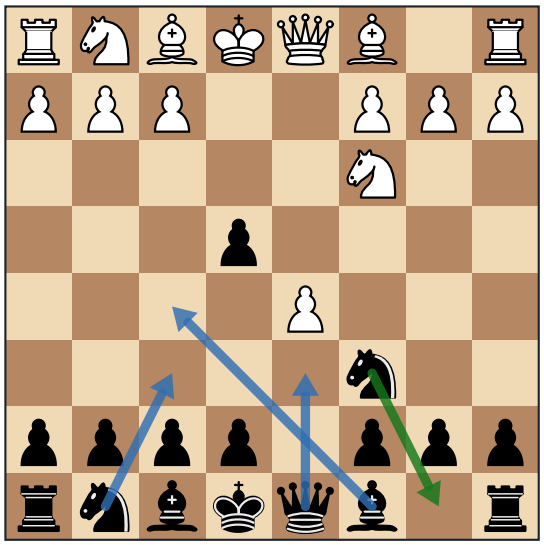
Nimzowitsch Defense

ECO B00 | 43 named lines | Semi-open / hypermodern defenses

In one sentence: Hypermodern and semi-open defenses avoid book fights: Black lets White build, then counterattacks the center.

Memory pattern: Let White build, then hit the center with ...c5 or ...e5.



Main line: 1.e4 Nc6 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 dxe4 4.d5

Key ideas

1. Black fianchettoes (Pirc/Modern) or hits e4 at once (Scandinavian, Alekhine).
2. White gets space and often a big center, but it can become a target.
3. Black's key breaks are ...c5, ...e5 and ...f5 at the right moment.
4. Develop quickly and avoid early queen moves unless they win time.
5. White should avoid overextension and keep pieces coordinated.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **+0.22** (equal, depth 17). Best: Nb8.

The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	Black avoids symmetrical development: a fianchetto (Pirc/Modern), a quick ...d5 (Scandinavian) or tempo play (Alekhine). White often gets a big center.
2. Where does my king go?	Black castles short behind the fianchetto; White often attacks with f4/Be3/Qd2/h4.
3. Best minor pieces?	Black: Bg7, Nf6/Nd7, ...c5/...e5 breaks. White: Nc3, Nf3, Be3, Bc4.
4. Main middlegame plan?	Black waits, then undermines the center with ...c5 or ...e5; White consolidates the center and develops quickly.
5. What does my opponent want?	White wants a big center and a fast attack; Black wants to hit the center in time.

The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.e4 Nc6 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 dxe4 4.d5

Move	Why it is played
1. e4	Occupies the center with a pawn.
1... Nc6	Develops the knight to c6.
2. d4	Take the center. Occupies the center with a pawn.
2... d5	Occupies the center with a pawn.
3. Nc3	Develops the knight to c3.
3... dxe4	Pawn capture: challenges the center and opens lines.
4. d5	Occupies the center with a pawn.



After 1.e4 Nc6 2.d4 d5

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.



Position after the line

Scandinavian Variation B00 | 13 lines

`1.e4 Nc6 2.d4 d5`

Stockfish: **+0.55** (slightly better for White, depth 15). Best next move: e5.
What to look for: Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop); d4 (take the center)
Sub-variations: Bogoljubow Variation, Exchange Variation, Aachen Gambit, Advance Variation



Position after the line

Kennedy Variation B00 | 10 lines

`1.e4 Nc6 2.d4 e5`

Stockfish: **+0.60** (slightly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: d5.
What to look for: Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop); d4 (take the center)
Sub-variations: Bielefelder Gambit, Hammer Gambit, Herford Gambit, Keres Attack

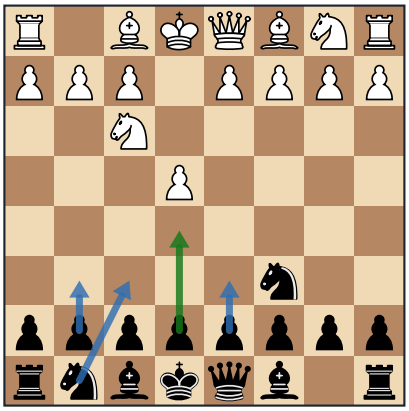


Position after the line

El Columpio Defense B00 | 4 lines

`1.e4 Nc6 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.e5 Ng4`

Stockfish: **+1.58** (clearly better for White, depth 16). Best next move: d4.
What to look for: Nc3 (develop); Nf3 (develop); d4 (take the center)
Sub-variations: El Columpio Gambit, Exchange Variation, Pin Variation

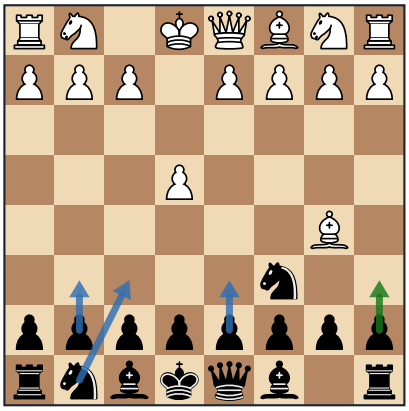


Position after the line

Declined Variation B00 | 1 lines

`1.e4 Nc6 2.Nf3`

Stockfish: **+0.22** (equal, depth 17). Best next move: e5.
What to look for: Nf6 (hit e4); g6 (fianchetto); Bg7 (long diagonal)

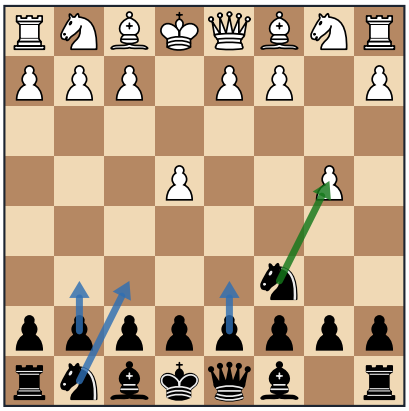


Position after the line

Pseudo-Spanish Variation B00 | 1 lines

`1.e4 Nc6 2.Bb5`

Stockfish: **+0.12** (equal, depth 17). Best next move: a6.
What to look for: Nf6 (hit e4); g6 (fianchetto); Bg7 (long diagonal)



Position after the line

Wheeler Gambit B00 | 1 lines

`1.e4 Nc6 2.b4`

Stockfish: **-0.47** (slightly better for Black, depth 16). Best next move: Nxb4.
What to look for: Nf6 (hit e4); g6 (fianchetto); Bg7 (long diagonal)

Expert and coach view

What a coach would tell you

Know the move-order tricks: in the Pirc, White's Austrian Attack (f4) is the main danger; in the Scandinavian, learn the queen retreat squares (a5, d6, d8). Always counterattack the center within the first 8-10 moves.

Why play it

Hypermodern and semi-open defenses avoid book fights: Black lets White build, then counterattacks the center.

Typical mistakes

- Letting White roll forward with e5 and f4 without a counter-break.
- Moving the queen repeatedly in the Scandinavian and falling behind in development.
- Fianchettoing without castling early and leaving the king exposed.

Typical tactics and traps

- Bxf7+ or Bxh7+ if Black's king sits behind a fianchetto without defenders.
- e5 forks or pins after Black ignores the center.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

Black aims to undermine White's center and reach an equal middlegame with flexible pawn structure.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **Nimzowitsch Defense (all lines)** B00
  `1.e4 Nc6`
  - **Declined Variation** B00
    `1.e4 Nc6 -> 2.Nf3`
  - **Pseudo-Spanish Variation** B00
    `1.e4 Nc6 -> 2.Bb5`
  - **Wheeler Gambit** B00
    `1.e4 Nc6 -> 2.b4`
  - **Colorado Countergambit** B00
    `1.e4 Nc6 -> 2.Nf3 f5`
  - **Franco-Nimzowitsch Variation** B00
    `1.e4 Nc6 -> 2.Nf3 e6`
  - **French Connection** B00
    `1.e4 Nc6 -> 2.Nc3 e6`
  - **Kennedy Variation** B00
    `1.e4 Nc6 -> 2.d4 e5`
    - **Linksspringer Variation** B00
      `1.e4 Nc6 2.d4 e5 -> 3.d5`
    - **Bielefelder Gambit** B00
      `1.e4 Nc6 2.d4 e5 -> 3.dxe5 Bc5`
    - **Hammer Gambit** B00
      `1.e4 Nc6 2.d4 e5 -> 3.dxe5 f6`
    - **Herford Gambit** B00
      `1.e4 Nc6 2.d4 e5 -> 3.dxe5 Qh4`
    - **de Smet Gambit** B00
      `1.e4 Nc6 2.d4 e5 -> 3.dxe5 d6`
    - **Keres Attack** B00
      `1.e4 Nc6 2.d4 e5 -> 3.dxe5 Nxe5 4.Nc3`
    - **Paulsen Attack** B00
      `1.e4 Nc6 2.d4 e5 -> 3.dxe5 Nxe5 4.Nf3`
    - **Main Line** B00
      `1.e4 Nc6 2.d4 e5 -> 3.dxe5 Nxe5 4.f4 Ng6`
    - **Riemann Defense** B00
      `1.e4 Nc6 2.d4 e5 -> 3.dxe5 Nxe5 4.f4 Nc6`
  - **Mikenas Variation** B00
    `1.e4 Nc6 -> 2.d4 d6`
  - **Neo-Mongoloid Defense** B00
    `1.e4 Nc6 -> 2.d4 f6`
  - **Pirc Connection** B00
    `1.e4 Nc6 -> 2.Nc3 g6`
  - **Scandinavian Variation** B00
    `1.e4 Nc6 -> 2.d4 d5`
    - **Advance Variation** B00
      `1.e4 Nc6 2.d4 d5 -> 3.e5`
    - **Bogoljubow Variation** B00
      `1.e4 Nc6 2.d4 d5 -> 3.Nc3`
      - **Brandics Gambit** B00
        `1.e4 Nc6 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 -> 3...a6`
      - **Erben Gambit** B00
        `1.e4 Nc6 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 -> 3...g6`
      - **Heinola-Deppe Gambit** B00
        `1.e4 Nc6 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 -> 3...e5`
      - **Vehre Variation** B00
        `1.e4 Nc6 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 -> 3...Nf6`
      - **Nimzowitsch Gambit** B00
        `1.e4 Nc6 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 -> 3...dxe4 4.d5 Ne5`
      - **Richter Gambit** B00
        `1.e4 Nc6 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 -> 3...dxe4 4.d5 Nb8 5.f3`

- **Aachen Gambit** B00
  `1.e4 Nc6 2.d4 d5 -> 3.exd5 Nb4`
- **Exchange Variation** B00
  `1.e4 Nc6 2.d4 d5 -> 3.exd5 Qxd5`
  - **Marshall Gambit** B00
    `1.e4 Nc6 2.d4 d5 3.exd5 Qxd5 -> 4.Nc3`
- **Williams Variation** B00
  `1.e4 Nc6 -> 2.Nf3 d6`
- **Woodchuck Variation** B00
  `1.e4 Nc6 -> 2.d4 a6`
- **Colorado Countergambit Accepted** B00
  `1.e4 Nc6 -> 2.Nf3 f5 3.exf5`
- **Hornung Gambit** B00
  `1.e4 Nc6 -> 2.d4 d5 3.Be3`
- **Breyer Variation** B00
  `1.e4 Nc6 -> 2.Nc3 Nf6 3.d4 e5`
- **El Columpio Defense** B00
  `1.e4 Nc6 -> 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.e5 Ng4`
  - **El Columpio Gambit** B00
    `1.e4 Nc6 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.e5 Ng4 -> 4.d4 d6 5.h3 Nh6 6.e6`
  - **Exchange Variation** B00
    `1.e4 Nc6 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.e5 Ng4 -> 4.d4 d6 5.h3 Nh6 6.exd6`
  - **Pin Variation** B00
    `1.e4 Nc6 2.Nf3 Nf6 3.e5 Ng4 -> 4.d4 d6 5.h3 Nh6 6.Bb5`

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

```
1.e4 Nc6 2.d4 d5 3.Nc3 dxe4 4.d5
```

Plan chain

White	Nc3 -> Nf3 -> d4 -> Bd2 -> Bc4
Black	Nf6 -> g6 -> Bg7 -> d6 -> c6

Three rules to remember

1. Let White build, then hit the center with ...c5 or ...e5.

2. Black waits, then undermines the center with ...c5 or ...e5; White consolidates the center and develops quickly.

3. White wants a big center and a fast attack; Black wants to hit the center in time.

Pawn structure in one line

Black avoids symmetrical development: a fianchetto (Pirc/Modern), a quick ...d5 (Scandinavian) or tempo play (Alekhine). White often gets a big center.